

CA.3 Inspection Sequence

The order California inspections happen in, what each inspector is actually looking at, the two California adds nobody expects, and a log to record every result as you go.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. California writes one building code for the whole state — Title 24 — but permits are issued by 58 counties and hundreds of incorporated cities, and state law lets each of them amend that code for local conditions. Confirm every item with the city or county building department that will issue your permit before you rely on it. Your permit card lists the inspections your job requires — it governs.

WHAT THE STATE SETS AND WHAT YOUR JURISDICTION SETS

The **definitions** below are statewide. They come from Section R109 of the California Residential Code — Chapter 1, Division II — and they say what condition the work must be in before each inspection can be called. The **list of inspections your particular job needs**, and the order your department calls them in, is local; it is printed on your permit card. Where the two differ, your permit card and your inspector govern.

California also gives the building official an express reserve power: under § R109.1.5 they "*shall have the authority to make or require any other inspections to ascertain compliance with this code and other laws.*" So the list is a floor, not a ceiling.

The rule that governs everything else

"Work shall not be done beyond the point indicated in each successive inspection without first obtaining the approval of the building official ... Any portions that do not comply shall be corrected and such portion shall not be covered or concealed until authorized by the building official." (§ R109.4)

And the standing note to § R109.1: *"Reinforcing steel or structural framework of any part of any building or structure shall not be covered or concealed without first obtaining the approval of the enforcing agency."* Covering work before it is signed off is the one mistake that reliably costs real money in California, because the remedy is opening it up again.

THE SEQUENCE — WHAT MUST BE COMPLETE BEFORE YOU CALL

Standard California residential inspection sequence

Inspection	What must be complete / what is verified	Code
1. Foundation and footings	After poles or piers are set, or trenches or basement areas excavated, any required forms erected, and any required reinforcing steel in place and supported — prior to the placing of concrete . Includes excavations for thickened slabs supporting bearing walls, partitions or equipment. Materials must be on site, except ready-mixed concrete.	§ R109.1.1
2. Concrete slab / under-floor	After in-slab or under-floor reinforcing steel and building service equipment, conduits and piping are installed, but before any concrete is placed or floor sheathing — including the subfloor — is installed .	§ R109.1.1.1
3. Rough plumbing, mechanical, gas, electrical	Prior to covering or concealment, before fixtures or appliances are set, and prior to framing inspection . Note the order: California puts the trade roughs <i>before</i> the frame inspection, not alongside it.	§ R109.1.2
4. Floodplain elevation	Only in a flood hazard area: upon placement of the lowest floor and before further vertical construction , documentation of the lowest-floor elevation, prepared and sealed by a registered design professional .	§ R109.1.3
5. Frame and masonry	After roof, masonry, framing, firestopping, draftstopping and bracing are in place, chimneys and vents to be concealed are complete, and the rough electrical, plumbing, heating, wires, pipes and ducts are approved .	§ R109.1.4
6. Moisture content verification	Moisture content of framing members is verified against the California Green Building Standards Code, Chapter 4, Division 4.5. Wet framing fails, and drying it is a schedule problem, not a paperwork one.	§ R109.1.4.1
7. Lath and gypsum board	After lathing and gypsum board, interior and exterior, is in place — but before any plastering is applied or joints and fasteners are taped and finished. On a stucco house this is its own milestone.	§ R109.1.4.2
8. Balcony / elevated walking surface waterproofing	Where a balcony or elevated walking surface is exposed to rain, snow or irrigation and the structural framing is protected by an impervious moisture barrier, no element of that barrier system may be concealed until inspected and approved .	§ R109.1.5.3
9. Fire-resistance-rated construction	Where rated construction is required — between dwelling units or because of location on the property — after lath or gypsum panels are in place but before plaster or taping. Joints and penetrations may not be concealed until inspected.	§ R109.1.5.1

Standard California residential inspection sequence

Inspection	What must be complete / what is verified	Code
10. Final	After the permitted work is complete and prior to occupancy . In a flood hazard area the elevation documentation must be in before the final. And the operation and maintenance manual must be in the building — see below.	§ R109.1.6

Quoted from the 2025 California Residential Code, Chapter 1, Division II, Administration, § R109.1.1 through § R109.1.6.2. Your jurisdiction will add its own — energy and HERS verification, solar, septic and well sign-offs, fire department inspections, and a grading final where a grading permit was issued. Verified August 2026.

Two inspections that are pure California — and one document at the final

Moisture content verification (§ R109.1.4.1). Most states inspect framing. California also checks that the framing is *dry enough*, against CALGreen Chapter 4, Division 4.5. If your lumber has been rained on and wrapped, you can fail a frame inspection on moisture alone. Plan your dry-in around it.

Balcony waterproofing (§ R109.1.5.3). California requires the impervious moisture barrier under any weather-exposed balcony, deck or elevated walking surface to be inspected **before it is covered**. If your design has any elevated exterior walking surface, that is a hold point most owner-builders discover after they have decked over it.

The operation and maintenance manual (§ R109.1.6.2). *"At the time of final inspection, a manual, compact disc, web-based reference or other media acceptable to the enforcing agency shall be placed in the building"* per CALGreen Chapter 4, Division 4.4. It is a real condition of your final. Start collecting appliance manuals, equipment data and maintenance instructions from your first delivery — assembling it the week of your final is miserable.

YOUR DUTIES, AND WHAT THE BUILDING OFFICIAL MAY DO

- **Calling the inspection is your job.** *"It shall be the duty of the permit holder or their agent to notify the building official that such work is ready for inspection,"* and the duty of the person requesting it *"to provide access to and means for inspection of such work."* Ladders, keys, a safe route — yours. (§ R109.3)
- **Special inspections are a separate regime.** Section R109.1.5.2 sends you to **California Building Code Chapter 17**. In California's seismic design categories these are common on engineered work. You pay for them, an approved special inspector performs them, and they are reported directly to the building official — ask at plan check whether your approved plans carry a special inspection schedule.

*One thing the code does **not** give you: a deadline. The enforcing agency must make the inspections "within a reasonable time" of your notification. There is no numeric statutory turnaround — any 24- or 48-hour figure you have heard is local practice, and in busy California jurisdictions it is often longer. Ask at your first inspection how far ahead to book, so it is not a surprise at your fifth.*

THE CERTIFICATE AT THE END — AND YOUR UTILITIES

"A building or structure shall not be used or occupied in whole or in part ... until the building official has issued a certificate of occupancy therefor." (§ R110.1) California uses the plain name — certificate of occupancy — and it issues after the building official inspects and finds no violations.

Worth knowing what it must contain (§ R110.2), because two of the items matter later: **the edition of the code under which the permit was issued** — your proof of which rulebook your house was built to — and **whether an automatic sprinkler system is provided and whether it was required**. Keep the certificate with your insurance papers; both entries answer questions an insurer or a buyer will eventually ask.

A **temporary certificate of occupancy** may be issued before the whole work is complete, "provided that such portion or portions shall be occupied safely," and the building official sets the period it is valid for (§ R110.3). A certificate can also be **suspended or revoked** in writing if it was issued in error or on incorrect information (§ R110.4).

No power and no water until they say so

"A person shall not make connections from a utility, a source of energy, fuel or power, or water system or sewer system to any building or system that is regulated by this code for which a permit is required, until approved by the building official." (§ R111.1)

Your utility will want the building department's release before it energizes permanent service, and the lead time on a new service connection in California is frequently measured in months, not weeks. Apply for permanent service **early** and ask the utility what it needs from the building department, in what form. A finished house waiting on a meter is a common and entirely avoidable ending.

WHEN AN INSPECTION GOES WRONG

Failures, changes, stop orders, appeals, and expiry

Situation	What to do	Authority
You failed	The building official must "notify the permit holder or an agent ... wherein the same fails to comply." Fix exactly what is named, and do not cover it until authorized. Re-inspection fees and how soon you may re-call are local — ask early.	§ R109.4
You want to change something	Approved construction documents govern. Get a revision approved before you build the change; on engineered work that usually means the engineer of record revises and re-stamps first.	§ R106
You got a stop work order	Work stops on the portion named until the order is released. Get the order in writing and address exactly what it cites.	§ R114

Failures, changes, stop orders, appeals, and expiry

Situation	What to do	Authority
You disagree with the ruling	There is a formal route: the code provides a means of appeal from the building official's decision. Ask your department for the appeal procedure and its deadline in writing — the clock is usually short and local.	§ R112
Your permit went stale	A permit remains valid if work on the site was commenced within 12 months of issuance and has not been abandoned. Extensions of not more than 180 days each may be granted in writing for justifiable cause — you have to ask.	H&S § 18938.6

*Permit validity is statutory, not merely a code provision: Health & Safety Code § 18938.6(a) and (b), added by AB 2913 (Stats. 2018, Ch. 655). The statutory test is **commencement within 12 months and no abandonment** — the 180-day figure in that section is the maximum length of a discretionary extension, not a rolling inspection clock. If your jurisdiction applies a rolling-inspection rule, that is its adopted code provision or ordinance; ask which, and get the expiry date printed on your permit.*

INSPECTION LOG — RECORD EVERY ONE

Fill this in as it happens, not from memory. If a result is ever disputed, or a later inspector questions earlier work, this page and your photographs are the record you have. Photograph every rough-in before it is covered, whatever the inspector says.

Inspection log

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes
Foundation / footings					
Slab / under-floor					
Plumbing rough					
Mechanical / gas rough					
Electrical rough					
Floodplain elevation					
Frame and masonry					
Moisture content					
Balcony waterproofing					
Lath / gypsum board					

Inspection log

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes
Insulation					
Energy / HERS verification					
Septic / well					
Final — building					

Certificate of occupancy issued: _____ Number: _____

Sources — every California claim in this document (verified August 2026)

What this document states	Authority
Foundation before concrete; slab and under-floor before concrete or subfloor	2025 CRC § R109.1.1, § R109.1.1.1
Trade roughs before the framing inspection; frame and masonry only after those roughs are approved	§ R109.1.2, § R109.1.4
Floodplain lowest-floor elevation, sealed, before going vertical	§ R109.1.3
Framing moisture content verified against CALGreen; lath and gypsum before plaster or taping	§ R109.1.4.1, § R109.1.4.2
Balcony moisture barrier and fire-rated construction not concealed until inspected; special inspections per CBC Chapter 17	§ R109.1.5.1–.5.3
Building official may require any other inspection; final after completion and prior to occupancy, with the operation and maintenance manual in the building	§ R109.1.5, § R109.1.6, § R109.1.6.2
Permit holder calls and provides access; reports of approved agencies may be accepted; no work past an inspection point without approval, and nothing concealed until authorized	§ R109.2, § R109.3, § R109.4
No occupancy without a certificate; it names the code edition and the sprinkler status; temporary CO available	§ R110.1, § R110.2, § R110.3
No utility connection until approved by the building official	§ R111.1
Permit valid on commencement within 12 months; 180-day extensions	H&S § 18938.6

Read any section cited above at [leginfo.legislature.ca.gov](https://leginfo.ca.gov) → California Law, or go straight to [leginfo.legislature.ca.gov/faces/codes_displaySection.xhtml?lawCode=BPC§ionNum=7044](https://leginfo.ca.gov/faces/codes_displaySection.xhtml?lawCode=BPC§ionNum=7044) and swap in the code and section. Codes used here: **BPC** Business and Professions, **HSC** Health and Safety, **LAB** Labor, **PRC** Public Resources, **CIV** Civil, **WAT** Water, **EDC** Education. Each page prints its own amendment history — check it against this kit's August 2026 verification.